

TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: Hi, I'm Tricia Davis-Muffett from Google for Education, and I'm here today with Matt Leger, senior research manager for IDC Worldwide Education Digital Strategies, to talk about higher education in the age of AI-- so what the current state looks like, how institutions can best prepare themselves and their students for a rapidly changing future. So, Matt, I know that you mentioned that when it comes to AI and higher education, we are seeing a digital divide emerge, with some institutions appointing AI leadership and racing ahead, while others are pausing out of caution. So even within an institution, you can have academic researchers investing heavily in AI, while administrators and faculty are making very different decisions. So from your vantage point at IDC, what are the long-term risks of this fragmentation, specifically for students, and how can institutions be more unified and strategic in their approach to AI?

MATT LEGER: Yeah.

Thanks, Tricia, and it's really great to be here.

Thanks for inviting me to do this.

And thanks, everyone, for joining us.

Yeah.

First and foremost, I am really starting to see in a lot of my conversations with higher ed leaders that there's fragmentation even within institutions, showing that some faculty are embracing AI.

Some are not.

Some departments are embracing AI.

Some are not.

And it's leading to a new version of the digital divide, where some students within an institution are getting AI interventions or AI-enabled learning or something like that, and some students are not. And that creates kind of a disparate experience for both sides.

The biggest risk there is that students who don't get that exposure are going to be left at a disadvantage compared to those who do get that kind of exposure.

And then that can interfere with their learning experience, their learning outcomes.

But also just talking about using AI safely in the real world, it puts them at a disadvantage where they don't learn how to use AI safely and effectively. We've seen this throughout the industry's history, where

we tend to start by banning some sort of emerging technology, so thinking about spell check back in the day or cell phones. When I was in college, I had some of my professors ban laptops.

And we're seeing this with AI, still.

Banning calculators did not make us better at math.

Banning cell phones made-- you could argue that some banning of that technology made it so that students really didn't know how to use it safely.

And now we see lots of issues with younger kids and young adults being addicted to their phones because they weren't taught how to use them safely.

AI is going to expose students to more risk if they don't learn how to use it safely.

And the classroom is really the only controlled environment where we actually have to expose students to these technologies in a safe way.

And so we should be doing that because that's what's going to set them up for success, whether it has to do with their job or not after they graduate. On top of that, there's the risk to the institution.

A lot of institutions are now facing pressure from students, from governments, from the business world to really demonstrate an ROI for the learning that happens there.

And if we have fragmented approaches to AI, you'll most certainly see fragmentation in student outcomes that's going to further muddy that ROI argument.

And that's something that institutions can really ill afford to do right now.

In terms of being more strategic and unified-- this is maybe going to ruffle a few feathers for some folks in higher ed-- but higher ed really, as an industry, needs to shift away from shared governance. I'm not saying we abandon the ideals of collaboration and grassroots support for institutional decision-making.

But to keep up with AI developments and ensure that our students succeed and our institutions continue to thrive, we have to really embrace a more timely and unified approach to AI than the one that shared governance models enable right now.

TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: Yeah, we're

hearing from a lot of our customers that we talk to that-- it's interesting.

We find that the schools often are reluctant to put a university-wide policy in place about AI, which then means that the faculty are not entirely

sure what they should put in place because they're looking for guidance.

But then they don't have a structure to put that into.

And then the students, because the faculty

haven't put a policy in place in the classroom,

believe maybe they're not allowed

to use it at all because they haven't been told what's allowed and what's not allowed.

And so then they either don't use anything,

or they sneak around and use their own personal stuff,

and then use it maybe in a way that the professors don't want.

So I feel like that piece of wanting to not

be too heavy-handed with the policies has actually created

a little bit more of a free for all because it x trickles down

from the university level to the faculty level

to the students, where everybody's

kind of unsure what's allowed, what's not allowed,

and everybody's making their own decisions,

rather than having a point of view.

Not every institution, but it does happen, for sure.

MATT LEGER: For sure.

And I will say, in fairness to those struggling

to develop those kind of unified policies

in terms of acceptable use and things

like that is-- this is true of every industry.

This isn't true of higher ed--

developing an AI policy is very, very difficult.

This technology is moving so fast

that what we're talking about right now on this recording

could be different two weeks from now,

let alone a year from now, two years from now.

So developing a policy that is always

relevant is really difficult. And so we always talk about

frameworks, guardrails, ethical frameworks

and mindsets for how to use it, and training, training,

training.

I cannot tell you enough, training is super,

super important, and just getting everyone exposed

to the technology.

I think there's always that first hump that faculty have

to get over and that students have

to get over for those who might be concerned about using it.

Once you get past that first exposure,

people are like, oh, OK.

This isn't what I thought it was.

Or oh, this is way more powerful than I thought it was,

or it's not.

And that's also important to learn too.

But yeah, policies are very difficult.

But we have to figure out a way to guide the entire institution forward.

And that's hard.

That is hard, and it's going to be hard.

But policies are something that a lot of institutions have to think about how to be flexible about.

TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: Yeah, for sure.

So the data is showing that a lot of faculty resist AI in instruction because they're afraid of cognitive offloading, that students just will stop thinking critically.

But there's also a deeper existential anxiety, I think, with higher ed leaders who are asking,

what's the value of higher education in the age of AI?

So how do we keep institutions not only realizing their value, but understanding the power of AI

to actually solve challenges and propel

their students and faculty and staff

forward and help with the evolution of education?

So I'm wondering if you have thoughts about that.

MATT LEGER: Yeah, absolutely.

And I think there's definitely an existential question

we should be asking ourselves because this technology is going to change what higher ed does and what its value is.

And that's fine.

I think that's perfectly OK.

But I absolutely hate this narrative

that's emerged that higher ed has no value in the age of AI because that's unequivocally not true.

First, let's not forget that higher ed actually played a pretty massive role in the development of AI going back decades.

AI researchers, where do you think they do all their research?

So we don't get to this place in history with technological development without higher ed.

We also won't get to the next evolution without them either.

We also don't develop medical breakthroughs, track and document our history, tackle environmental, social, economic challenges without our institutions of higher learning.

It's about time that people remembered that.

It's also time that industry leaders do a better job telling that story.

Second, in the AI world, it's actually more essential than ever that people know how to write well.

Because if you can write well, then you can prompt well, and you can communicate clearly with AI systems.

You'll outperform your peers who have weaker writing

skills in the job if you can write well, which higher ed does pretty well.

To identify hallucinations, you need expert knowledge in a given area.

You need the ability to think critically, analyze vast amounts of data and information.

And you need research skills to validate AI outputs.

These are all things that higher ed teaches you to do.

And additionally, AI is only as effective as the volume and quality of the data that it's trained on.

And if there's one thing higher ed is great for it's collecting vast amounts of high-quality data, especially in areas where there isn't any data right now.

So like it or not, we need higher ed now more than ever.

It's just going to change in terms of what they do and what their value is.

And the last thing I'll say, AI can help institutions improve in areas where they're actually already differentiated from peers and competitors.

So one example I recently wrote about is UNC Chapel Hill, University of North Carolina, that's leveraging AI to accelerate academic and scientific research in areas where they have unique data sets or data sets unique to their research functions.

They're currently exploring how they can apply AI to those data sets, so that they can uncover new discoveries that their researchers hadn't yet gotten their hands on.

Babson College is another one that comes to mind where they are putting AI into the hands of their entrepreneurship students to help them build businesses and solve problems with AI.

This is helping them make new advances in an academic area that they're already kind of well known for.

So this is also a differentiating technology for them,

TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: I think North Carolina is clearly at the forefront.

We were at NC State this summer also with working with them and getting all their faculty trained and ready.

And the students were super excited about how they could be using Gemini for Education also.

So I think it's great to see large institutions like that embracing AI and really

working with their faculty and staff to figure out how can we make this additive to education rather than something that takes away from critical thinking or advancing human knowledge.

So as of late last year in the US alone,

Gemini for Education was integrated into over 1,000 US higher ed institutions and reaching more than 10 million students.

And so I think it's reasonable to say that AI literacy is not a luxury, but a core component of career readiness.

So what are your thoughts on this assertion?

And what steps can institutions take to promote AI fluency and the responsible use of AI?

MATT LEGER: Yeah, absolutely.

I would say this is absolutely true, that AI literacy is really critical for career readiness, not just for the jobs of the future, like for jobs right now.

In the business world, AI has been adopted faster than any technology in history.

And adoption is really only going to accelerate moving forward.

So students need AI literacy skills to get the jobs of today and tomorrow.

We already discussed the importance of embedding AI into curriculum a little bit earlier, so I won't belabor the point there.

But I will say that that's easier said than done.

So a lot of institutions need to focus really hard on getting that right.

And I'm thinking about SUNY Albany, State University of New York, my alma mater, who undertook a massive effort to hire a bunch of AI faculty in the last couple of years and embed AI into curriculum across their programs.

I also believe this week, if I'm not mistaken, Purdue University became the first university in the US to make AI skills development a graduation requirement for their students.

So we're starting to see that a lot of institutions are really taking this seriously.

But doing that takes a lot of focused effort, resources, attention to change management, and training to get faculty upskilled on how to embed AI into curriculum and into learning experiences and how to apply it to student lessons.

After we get that right, I would say we have to then start thinking about applied AI learning.

So more than just understanding conceptually how AI works, based on lecture-based learning and structured assignments, students need to be applying AI to real-world problems-- so thinking about collaborative and project-based learning, partnerships with employers to develop internships where students are doing AI projects in a real-world work environment.

Experiential learning is going to be the next critical thing for a lot of institutions to focus on. And then looking forward beyond that, I would say that AI literacy, or what we understand AI literacy to be or its definition, is going to be changing over time.

What is good prompting skills right now or information literacy right now might look very different a year or five years from now and so on.

So we will need to be iterative on this, where institutions are constantly evaluating their courses and degree programs to ensure that the curriculum and skills that they're teaching the students are aligned with what's actually happening and where the industry is going.

So you need to build in processes to ensure that you can continuously iterate on your curriculum.

You also need partnerships with companies like Google, also Microsoft, OpenAI, all the other big AI companies you can think of, to ensure that you can effectively do that because that gives you access to the latest and greatest expertise and technology to do that well.

TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: Yeah.

We've been really excited to see some schools really embracing AI across their entire ecosystem of students, but also even the people around the institution.

So like the Ohio State University, they have made every freshmen take an AI literacy course as they come into the institution.

And they have a goal that every student graduates as an expert in the field, their field of study, and as fully competent in AI.

And they're also making some of that training, that AI literacy training, available to parents, to people taking extension courses, sort of everybody around the university because they really are taking to heart that the need to create an AI-ready and AI-literate workforce in Ohio.

So I love to see a school embrace AI literacy in that way.

And I feel confident that they're going to create a workforce that is ready to take this on and to leapfrog others as they move out into the world.

So, Matt, turning this a little bit to a personal question.

As an analyst, I'm sure that you have a lot of opportunities to use AI.

You're a researcher.

You're a writer.

So given all of that and the way that you conduct research and generate and share insights with your colleagues

and with institutions, what are some of the ways that you're using AI in your day to day or as part of bigger initiatives?

MATT LEGER: Yeah, that's a big one.

It's funny being an analyst in this space covering this technology.

There's very few professions that have been transformed so quickly than the analyst role.

So I've been living this since the moment ChatGPT came out, and that became everyone's first idea of what AI is.

And obviously, we've evolved to have a lot more tools than that.

My job has changed drastically over the last three, four years since we've been introduced to this.

So first is back in the day, a year or two years ago, I'd be doing a lot of manual, manual research.

So that would include-- if I have a research question I'm trying to answer, I'd go out into Google

and search as many things as I can, gather all the articles and academic journal articles

I could find, pull them over into a document, and then start doing a massive literature review.

I'd read through everything, write notes, organize an outline, and then that

would help develop the writing.

So I used to say, if I had an hour to solve a research question, I'd

spend 55 minutes researching it and five minutes actually writing about it.

That equation has kind of flipped a little bit, where I'm not necessarily doing all of the gathering of information in the same way.

I'm actually using tools like Gemini, like Perplexity, like OpenAI with deep research capabilities to go out and find all the information that I'm looking for.

So I'm not combing through many, many, many, many, many pages of whatever search engine I'm using

to gather all the articles I want to read,

and basically spending my time now validating that all those sources that are sent to me are accurate.

And I'm going through and spending time thinking really hard about the problem I'm

trying to answer, rather than spending half of my time or more just gathering information.

So just in the early of research and end-to-end process, it's really flipped the equation.

So I can actually spend a lot more of my mental energy really thinking about the problem rather than gathering information.



It's also been really helpful in organizing thoughts when my thoughts can't be fully developed straight in my head. So sometimes, as a researcher, you have a million ideas flowing and bouncing off different parts of your brain, and you're trying to figure out how to organize it in a way that would make sense to someone who's not in my head. Sometimes that's really hard to do. So I've actually used AI as a thought partner to help me organize my thoughts. I'll dump all my notes, everything I can into whatever tool I'm using, and I say, here's the question I'm trying to answer. Here's what I'm trying to do. I give it the fact that I'm a research analyst, who's the audience I'm trying to serve, all those things, and it helps me organize my thoughts. So instead of getting stuck not being able to get my thoughts on paper, it helps me get the ideas out of my head. And then I also use it kind of as a peer reviewer viewer sometimes. I try to do that with some of my colleagues here at IDC because I just like the human interaction of going back and forth and debating ideas. But sometimes my colleagues are busy. And so I will dump whatever research I write into the tools we're using here, and I will ask it to peer review and point out flaws in my argument, or areas where I can maybe tighten up the language, where I have these run-on sentences that I need to fix. Or just like, hey-- and I would give it a persona like, hey, act as if you're a academic peer reviewer looking at a journal article. Tell me what I'm missing. Tell me where my thoughts are flawed. Every which way that I do research can now be AI-supported or AI-enabled in some way. And it's truly incredible. Thinking back a couple of years ago how I used to do research, I'm like, I don't even know how we used to do that because it's so, so different now. TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: Yeah. It does feel a little bit like-- I remember a preinternet time when you had to follow things to the shelves. And oh, I'm going to find this chapter of this book and pull up this article or whatever.

And yeah, really is really game-changing.

I also use NotebookLM a lot, where I'll find my core sources for something.

For instance, if I'm thinking about how to position a new product, and I'll pull the-- these are my source documents, and this is what I want to rely on.

And sometimes you're thinking about the problem and you're like, oh, I wonder if any of this includes this detail, or if we've thought about this, and being able to ask that question of core sources that you've put into one notebook is pretty incredible.

And I don't know about you, but I also I'm a little scattered sometimes and have a lot of things coming at me.

We have this great agentic tool within Google that we've built, where every morning it sends me a daily briefing.

It goes through my calendar, my chats, my email, and tells me the things I need to focus on today, which is incredibly helpful.

Because otherwise, it would take me an hour to just get through all of that and figure out what I need to do.

And I almost certainly would miss some things.

So I'm very grateful for AI.

And I also feel like I wonder how I ever did this before I had these tools available.

MATT LEGER: I think that's going to be the next stage for me.

I need my own little agent assistant to help me with that.

TRICIA DAVIS-MUFFETT: Yeah, it's pretty good.

It's pretty good.

I highly recommend building a little agent for yourself.

Well, Matt, thank you so much for taking the time to speak with us and for sharing your insights on AI and higher education and the future of work, really.

And for those watching this video, we invite you to share with us in the comments the ways that your own institution has responsibly integrated AI to support students, staff, and faculty, and where you see things going in the future.

Thank you, everyone.

MATT LEGER: Thanks for having me.